



P54 · 30 PAGES, PRINTABLE + FILLABLE

The Pregnancy + Work Planner

A thirty-page planner for navigating pregnancy at work. Pre-announcement research on company policy and legal rights. Timing decision for telling your manager. The script for telling them. The HR conversation script. Accommodations checklist. Mat-leave prep with a real handoff document template. The "what if I don't come back" page. Practical, navigation- focused.

Soothemade **Notes**

A SMALL APOTHECARY OF PRINTABLES · MADE SLOWLY

A note before you start

You are pregnant. You are also working. You have a 10am meeting tomorrow, an OB appointment Thursday afternoon, and you have not told anyone at the office yet.

Almost no widely-used resource respects all three of those facts at the same time. Most pregnancy books assume a stay-at-home transition. Most career advice assumes you are not currently growing a human. The actual experience of pregnancy at a job, telling the boss, asking for accommodations, planning the handoff, deciding about return, falls into the gap this planner is built to fill.

It is not legal advice. It points you to your country's laws. It is not financial advice. It points you to your HR. It is the prep work between you and the conversations you need to have.

With care, Maya

This is a planning tool, not legal or financial advice. For specific questions about your rights at work, please consult an employment attorney, your union representative, or your HR department. For benefits and pay questions during leave, please consult your HR and a financial advisor.

How to use this planner

- Start with the pre-announcement research page. Learn what you have a right to before you announce.
- The script pages can be edited freely. They are starting points.
- The handoff document template is meant to be filled in well before leave starts.
- Some pages benefit from being shared with the partner.
- The “what if I don’t come back” page is at the back. Read it whenever you need to.

Pre-announcement: know what you are entitled to

Before you tell anyone, know what your rights are. Knowledge changes the conversation.

RESEARCH CHECKLIST

YOUR COUNTRY'S LAWS

- ☐ Parental / maternity leave: paid, unpaid, length, eligibility
- ☐ Job-protection during leave
- ☐ Pregnancy discrimination protections
- ☐ Pregnancy-related accommodation rights

US-SPECIFIC LAWS (if applicable)

- ☐ FMLA, up to 12 weeks unpaid, job-protected leave for eligible employees (50+ employee company, 12 months employed, 1250 hours worked).
- ☐ PWFA, Pregnant Workers Fairness Act, reasonable accommodations required by employers with 15+ employees.
- ☐ ADA, Americans with Disabilities Act, applies to pregnancy complications and related conditions in some cases.
- ☐ PUMP Act, protections for breastfeeding parents (covered in P17, more later).
- ☐ State-specific paid leave (CA, NY, NJ, RI, WA, etc.)

UK / EU / CANADA / AUS users: your country has parental-leave laws specific to your employment. Look them up or consult your HR.

YOUR COMPANY'S POLICY

- ☐ How many weeks of paid maternity / parental leave?
- ☐ Paid at what percentage of salary?
- ☐ Paternity / non-birthing-parent leave?
- ☐ Adoption leave?
- ☐ Short-term disability benefits (US)?
- ☐ Health insurance during leave?
- ☐ Holidays / PTO that accrue during leave?
- ☐ Required return date?
- ☐ Phased return options?
- ☐ Pumping room facilities?

WHERE TO FIND THE POLICY

- ☐ Employee handbook (often on the intranet)
- ☐ HR portal
- ☐ Direct conversation with HR (you can ask hypothetically before announcing)

WHO ELSE HAS DONE THIS AT MY COMPANY

Talking to a colleague who has already taken maternity leave is one of the most useful pre-conversations. They know what the policy looks like in practice, not just on paper.

Who I could ask:

What I want to ask them:

When to tell, the decision

Timing is yours. The decision involves multiple factors.

THE TIMING OPTIONS

EARLY (BEFORE 12 WEEKS)

PROS:

- Cannot hide much sickness or fatigue
- Manager can plan further out
- Eligible for accommodations sooner

CONS:

- Higher early-pregnancy risk window
- Some workplaces treat you differently from this point
- You have to tell again if anything goes wrong

MIDDLE (12 TO 20 WEEKS)

PROS:

- Past the steepest risk window
- Body has not made it obvious yet
- You have time to think through the conversation
- Manager has reasonable time to plan

CONS:

- Less time for accommodations to ramp up
- Some accommodations require provider letter, which takes time

LATE (AFTER 20 WEEKS)

PROS:

- Maximum control over your own news for longer
- Less time for office to treat you differently

CONS:

- Body has often given it away by now
- Less time for the company to plan
- Less time for accommodations
- Can feel awkward if they noticed weeks ago

WHAT IS MY SITUATION

How visible is my pregnancy right now?

How much do I trust my workplace to handle this well?

Am I in line for a promotion, project, or change in role that the news might affect?

Are there office friends I want to tell before the announcement?

MY DECISION

I am telling my manager around week: _____

I am telling HR around week: _____

I am telling my team around week: _____

I am telling clients (if relevant) around week: _____

Script for telling your manager

A script is a starting point. Edit it for your relationship + your manager's style.

THE SCRIPT (CALM VERSION)

"I wanted to share some news. I am pregnant. My due date is approximately [date]. I am planning to take [length] of leave.

I'm sharing now because I want to make sure we have plenty of time to plan the work side of things. I have some thoughts on how to handle [specific project / responsibility / time]. I'd love to find a time in the next [couple of weeks / month] to walk through it with you.

For now, I'd appreciate keeping it between us until [timing]. Then I will share more broadly."

THE SCRIPT (IF YOU HAVE A WORK-RELATED ANXIETY)

"I want to be upfront that I am thinking about a few things about how this will affect my role. Specifically [travel / on-call / physical task / hours / specific project]. Can we talk about how we might handle that?"

THE SCRIPT (IF MANAGER IS SUPPORTIVE BY DEFAULT)

The above, but warmer. They will say warm things back. Let them.

THE SCRIPT (IF MANAGER IS NEUTRAL OR POSSIBLY NOT SUPPORTIVE)

The above, but with backup. Document the conversation in writing afterward (an email to yourself summarizing, or an email to them confirming).

WHAT NOT TO SAY (UNTIL YOU HAVE THOUGHT IT THROUGH)

- Specific return date (you may want to revisit this)
- "I'm not sure if I'll come back" (even if it's true. this is not the meeting for it)
- Anything that compromises your bargaining position before HR

WHAT TO HAVE ON HAND

- Your due date

- Your planned leave length (rough)
- Any immediate work-handoff thoughts
- Calendar to schedule the follow-up

WHAT TO DO AFTER THE MEETING

- ☐ Email your manager a recap of what you discussed.
- ☐ Note the date you told them.
- ☐ Note their response (in this journal, for your records).

THE RECAP EMAIL

"Thanks for the conversation today. To summarize:

- I am pregnant, due approximately [date].
- I plan to take [length] of leave.
- We agreed to follow up on [date] to discuss handoff details.
- For now, this is confidential.

Let me know if I missed anything. Looking forward to working through this together."

WHAT THEY SAID (FILL IN AFTER YOUR CONVERSATION)

Date of meeting: _____

Their initial reaction:

Their stated plan for handoff coverage:

Anything concerning they said:

Anything reassuring:

Script for the HR conversation

HR is a different conversation. They are the keepers of the policy details, the paperwork, the leave-coordination.

THE INITIAL HR CONVERSATION

"I am pregnant, due approximately [date]. I'm reaching out to understand the leave process at our company. Can we walk through:

1. What our official maternity / parental / disability leave policy is
2. What paperwork I need to complete and when
3. How my benefits work during leave (health insurance, PTO, retirement)
4. How pay works during leave
5. What accommodations are available if needed
6. What the formal job-protection situation is
7. What the process is for returning"

WHAT TO GET IN WRITING

Ask for the policy documents in writing. Read them. Re-read them.
Ask HR to clarify anything that is unclear, in writing.

Documents I have collected:

- ☐ Maternity / parental leave policy
- ☐ Short-term disability policy (US)
- ☐ FMLA paperwork (US, if applicable)
- ☐ State paid leave application (if applicable)
- ☐ Benefits-during-leave summary
- ☐ Return-to-work process
- ☐ Accommodation request process

QUESTIONS HR MAY NOT VOLUNTEER

- Does the company top off short-term disability to full pay?
- Are there any conditions where I would owe back any paid leave?
- What happens to my PTO accrual during leave?
- Can I use accumulated PTO before / after / during leave?
- Is there a phased return option?
- Is there back-pay if my leave starts earlier than expected?

THE RECAP EMAIL TO HR

Same as with manager. Document everything.

"Thanks for explaining the leave process today. To confirm what I understood:

- The company offers [X] weeks of paid maternity leave.
- This is based on [eligibility criteria].
- I will [or will not] receive [percentage] of my salary.
- The relevant paperwork is [list].
- I need to submit [paperwork] by [date].

Please let me know if I have any of this wrong."

Accommodations checklist

Pregnancy often comes with physical and logistical needs. The PWFA in the US (and similar laws elsewhere) require reasonable accommodations.

COMMON PREGNANCY ACCOMMODATIONS

PHYSICAL

- ☐ More frequent bathroom breaks
- ☐ Ability to keep water at desk / station
- ☐ Modified or assigned seating (if standing job)
- ☐ Limits on heavy lifting (your provider gives you the limit)
- ☐ Limits on extended standing
- ☐ Stool to sit at standing workstation
- ☐ Closer parking
- ☐ Modified uniform if applicable

SCHEDULE

- ☐ Time off for prenatal appointments
- ☐ Modified start / end time for morning sickness
- ☐ Limits on overtime
- ☐ Limits on night shift / shift work
- ☐ Limits on weekend work
- ☐ Flexible remote work (if reasonable for the role)

ENVIRONMENTAL

- ☐ Reduced exposure to specific chemicals
- ☐ Reduced exposure to extreme temperature
- ☐ Reduced exposure to heavy noise
- ☐ Reduced exposure to certain infectious diseases (healthcare)
- ☐ Adjustment to vibrating equipment

JOB DUTIES

- ☐ Temporary reassignment from a specific task
- ☐ Adjustment in customer-facing duties (if appropriate)
- ☐ Modified travel requirements

THE LETTER FROM MY PROVIDER

For most formal accommodation requests, you need a letter from your obstetric provider. The letter typically:

- States that you are pregnant

- States the relevant restriction (e.g. "Patient should not lift more than 20 lbs")
- States the duration (often "until 6 weeks postpartum")
- Does NOT need to share medical details beyond what is needed

The provider's nurse line is often the right place to request this.

What I need the letter to say:

Date I requested it: _____

Date I received it: _____

Date I submitted to HR: _____

ACCOMMODATIONS I AM REQUESTING

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

ACCOMMODATIONS APPROVED (FILL IN AFTER)

ACCOMMODATIONS DENIED OR DELAYED (FILL IN AFTER)

If denied, the next step is often the EEOC in the US, your union if applicable, or an employment attorney. Document everything.

Mat-leave prep: the handoff document

This is the most important pre-leave document. A solid handoff doc earns you a calm leave.

THE HANDOFF DOCUMENT TEMPLATE

ROLE OVERVIEW

My role in one paragraph:

CRITICAL DEADLINES OR EVENTS DURING MY LEAVE

Date:	Event / deadline:	Who is handling:

CURRENT PROJECTS (one row each)

PROJECT 1

Name + summary:

Current status:

Next milestones:

Who is covering during leave:

Where to find the files:

Key contacts (external):

PROJECT 2

Name + summary:

Current status:

Next milestones:

Who is covering:

Where to find the files:

Key contacts:

PROJECT 3

Name + summary:

Current status:

Next milestones:

Who is covering:

Where to find the files:

Key contacts: _____

RECURRING RESPONSIBILITIES

Task	Who is covering during leave
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____

KEY CONTACTS (INTERNAL)

_____ (role: _____)
_____ (role: _____)
_____ (role: _____)

KEY CONTACTS (EXTERNAL)

_____ (company: _____)
_____ (company: _____)

PASSWORDS + ACCESS (do this securely, not in plain text)

- ☐ Shared passwords managed via [tool]
- ☐ Vendor accounts I am the contact for: list
- ☐ Tools where my account is the admin: list

WHAT TO DO IF SOMETHING URGENT COMES UP

First, try: _____
If that does not work, try: _____
Only if truly urgent, contact: _____ (me)

Definition of "truly urgent" (set this in writing):

EXPECTED RETURN DATE

Note: I reserve the right to update this within the legal framework of my leave.

Ramp-down plan + out-of-office

LAST 4 WEEKS BEFORE LEAVE

WEEK 4 (4 weeks out)

- ☐ Handoff doc complete and shared with manager + covers
- ☐ Confirm coverage for each recurring meeting
- ☐ Schedule check-in with covers
- ☐ Begin transitioning new work away
- ☐ Confirm all benefits paperwork submitted

WEEK 3 (3 weeks out)

- ☐ Shadow / observe covers handling some of your tasks
- ☐ Out-of-office message drafted
- ☐ Email auto-response drafted
- ☐ Phone forwarding plan, if applicable
- ☐ Backup ensure pregnancy might come early

WEEK 2 (2 weeks out)

- ☐ Take a day off if possible just to rest
- ☐ Final handoff conversations
- ☐ Clean inbox
- ☐ Write yourself a return-to-work prep doc (a "what was I in the middle of when I left" note)

WEEK 1 (last week)

- ☐ Out-of-office activated, set for full leave period
- ☐ Phone forwarded
- ☐ Final goodbyes / "see you in a few months"
- ☐ Bag packed for the hospital (if delivering soon)
- ☐ Final email: "Hi, today is my last day before leave. I will return around [date]. In the meantime, [cover] is handling all incoming [type of work]."

THE OUT-OF-OFFICE MESSAGE

"Hi, I am on parental leave through approximately [date]. I am not checking email during this time.

For urgent matters related to [project / area], please contact [name] at [email].

For everything else, I will respond when I return.

Thank you."

(Some people prefer a more personal tone. Some prefer the minimal. Either works.)

Mid-leave: life admin while you are off

A few things commonly need attention during leave. None of them are work.

DURING LEAVE, CHECKLIST

PAPERWORK

- ☐ Birth certificate filed (hospital usually starts. you may need to follow up with the state)
- ☐ Social Security number applied for the baby
- ☐ Baby added to your health insurance (often within 30 days of birth)
- ☐ Update beneficiaries (life insurance, retirement) to include the baby
- ☐ Update your will if you have one (or write one)
- ☐ HSA / FSA updated if applicable
- ☐ Childcare arrangements confirmed for return

CONNECTION (low-stakes)

- ☐ Send one "thinking of you" note to a work friend (if you want)
- ☐ Update your LinkedIn / professional profile only if YOU want to share publicly

MENTAL HEALTH

- ☐ Reach out to a perinatal therapist if needed
- ☐ Check in with your provider at the postpartum visit

WHAT I AM NOT DOING DURING LEAVE

- ☐ Reading work email
- ☐ Joining "quick" calls
- ☐ Solving urgent problems
- ☐ Taking on "small" projects

The leave is the leave. The work will be there when you come back.

Return-to-work pre-plan

This is the high-level pre-plan. P31 (Returning-to-Work Plan) is the deeper companion.

THE PRE-PLAN

CHILDCARE

Type: _____
Start date: _____
Cost per month: _____
Backup if primary is sick: _____

PUMPING (if applicable)

See P17 Back-to-Work Pumping Planner for the full plan.

RETURN DATE

Earliest possible: _____
Ideal: _____
Required by: _____

PHASED OR FULL RETURN

- ☐ Full-time, full week
- ☐ Reduced schedule for first weeks
- ☐ Reduced schedule permanent
- ☐ Different role
- ☐ Other: _____

THE FIRST WEEK BACK

Conversations I want to have:

THINGS I AM ANTICIPATING WILL BE HARD

THE THERAPIST / SUPPORT I AM RESERVING

A NOTE

Coming back is often harder than people expect. You are not the same person you were when you left. The job is not the same. The relationships are not the same. Give yourself permission

to take the first month as adjustment, not as a referendum on whether you can do this.

P31 has the full planner for the return.

“What if I don’t come back”

This page is for the person whose plans change.

THE REASONS THIS QUESTION COMES UP

- ☐ Childcare costs make the job a net negative financially
- ☐ The bond with the baby makes the separation harder than expected
- ☐ A health situation (yours or the baby's) changes things
- ☐ The job has changed in a way you do not want
- ☐ You realized you were not happy there before pregnancy
- ☐ A different opportunity has come up
- ☐ Family circumstances have changed
- ☐ The values shift of parenthood is real

THE OPTIONS

FULL EXIT

Resign at the end of leave.

Practical: do not resign UNTIL leave is exhausted (you may lose benefits or paid weeks otherwise). Talk to HR about timing.

REDUCED SCHEDULE

Come back part-time. Negotiate during leave or at return.

DIFFERENT ROLE

Come back to a different role within the company that works better for parenthood.

PHASED EXIT

Come back for a defined transition period, then leave.

LEAVE EXTENSION

Some places offer additional unpaid leave. Discuss with HR.

CAREER PIVOT

A different career, eventually. See P47 Stay-at-Home Parent Transition Planner for the deeper companion if you are moving toward full-time parenting.

WHAT TO DO BEFORE YOU MAKE THIS DECISION

- ☐ Talk with your partner about the financial picture
- ☐ Run the actual numbers (childcare cost, lost income, tax

implications, retirement contributions)

- ☐ Talk with someone who has done what you are considering
- ☐ Give yourself at least a few weeks back at work before deciding (some of what feels impossible at week 1 back is manageable by week 8)
- ☐ Do not announce the decision until you are sure

WHAT I AM CURRENTLY THINKING

WHAT I WANT TO DECIDE BY (date):

WHAT I WILL DECIDE AFTER (specific event or date):

A REMINDER: THE DECISION IS YOURS. SOME COLLEAGUES WILL HAVE OPINIONS. SOME WILL JUDGE. NEITHER GROUP IS PAYING YOUR BILLS OR RAISING YOUR CHILD. THE DECISION RESPECTS YOUR FAMILY, NOT THEIR OPINION.

A final note

You did the planning that most pregnant employees do not get to do.

You researched your rights. You scripted the conversation. You documented the handoff. You decided what you want for the return. You gave yourself permission for the “what if I don’t come back” page.

Whatever your work situation looks like a year from now, you walked through this season prepared. That is rare. It is also the thing that makes the difference between feeling like work happened TO you and feeling like you navigated it.

You are not the first to do this. You are part of a long line of people figuring this out. The line gets longer when people document their playbooks for the next person.

Good luck. Both with the leave and with everything after.

With care, Maya



Soothemade *Notes*

*Made for the version of you no one tells you about, the
one at four in the morning, the one in the parking lot, the
one who doesn't recognize her own week.*

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